

Saada Amadu

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EDUCATION

University of California, Berkeley

2024 – Present

Ph.D. in City and Regional Planning — Concentration: Food Systems and Applied Data Science

Central European University, Budapest, Hungary

2017

M.S. in Environmental Sciences & Policy, 3.5 GPA

Thesis: From Land Grabbing to Sustainable Land Investments: Effects of Large-Scale Land Transactions on the Environment and Rural Livelihoods in Ghana

College of Staten Island, New York, NY

2016

B.A. in International Studies, 3.7 GPA

Honors Thesis: State and Non-Governmental Organization Influences on Sustainable Agricultural Practices in Senegal

Study abroad: Université Paris Ouest Nanterre La Défense (2015), City University of Hong Kong (2016)

TEACHING EXPERIENCE

University of California, Berkeley — Graduate Student Instructor

Fall 2025

- Assisted with mini lectures, assignments, and demos
- Taught 2 sections of 30 students and grading

PROFESSIONAL EXPERIENCE

Export Trading Group — Agribusiness Intern, Malawi

May 2025 – Aug. 2025

- Conducted technical due diligence and sustainability assessments on agroforestry carbon-credit projects for 2,000+ smallholder farmers, modeling carbon sequestration potentials and designing revenue-share frameworks to attract impact investors.
- Designed a Climate Desk toolkit and accompanying visuals for smallholder farmers on carbon credits, soil-health benefits, and revenue projections.

Resilient Cities Network — Program Manager, Climate Resilience & Equity, New York

Jun. 2022 – Present

- Collaborated with city officials, community-based organizations, and stakeholders to identify and scale community-centric resilience solutions addressing climate risks and socioeconomic inequities.
- Designed and conducted household surveys and key informant interviews across 250+ households, informing tailored interventions for extreme heat and flooding in four frontline environmental justice communities.
- Conducted pre-feasibility studies and identified 10 viable climate resilience projects, leading to the selection and initiation of 5 projects with a combined budget of \$500,000, benefiting over 10,000 urban residents.
- Led the Urban Eats campaign to inspire cities to adopt circular and resilient food systems and attract funding support.
- Spearheaded the technical development and global deployment of the Resilient Infrastructure for Diversity and Equity (RIDE) Scorecard across 10 cities, with potential to impact over 2 million urban residents.

Matriark Foods — Project Consultant, New York

Oct. 2021 – Mar. 2022

- Researched and recommended vegetables and producers in line with sustainable sourcing criteria.
- Conducted upcycled foods market research and quantitative analysis to inform go-to-market strategy.
- Designed and implemented company-wide environmental, social, and governance reporting processes.

Sky High Farm — Food Access Program Consultant, New York

May 2021 – Oct. 2021

- Utilized sustainable agriculture practices to produce food for distribution to the food-insecure.
- Conducted needs assessments and collaborated with community organizations on food security initiatives.

Rethink Food — Policy Researcher, New York

Feb. 2020 – Apr. 2021

- Co-led strategic development and execution of Rethink Food's food policy strategy, legislative agenda, and revenue goals.
- Facilitated 30+ strategic partnerships with restaurants, directing funding and resources to combat food insecurity.
- Led targeted lobbying and advocacy campaigns, liaising with elected officials and community leaders.
- Identified viable government funding opportunities and prepared grant applications and contract proposals.

Spaces — Community Manager, New York

Dec. 2018 – Jan. 2020

- Co-managed a seven-floor co-working space with over 100 companies.
- Built an active community through client programming; partnered with intergovernmental agencies on pitch competitions and coordinated logistics across five events with 300+ attendees.

Schneider Electric — Sustainability Analyst, Budapest

Jan. 2018 – Aug. 2018

- Oversaw sustainability reporting for 15 companies, achieving a 10% reduction in energy consumption and 15% reduction in carbon emissions.
- Managed 20+ electricity and gas utility vendors and researched climate policy and compliance strategies for clients.

Impact Hub Budapest — Community Host, Budapest, Hungary

Feb. 2017 – Jul. 2017

- Welcomed co-working members and space guests; fostered connections between community members to support innovation.

HONORS AND AWARDS

Mentored Research Award (Full Tuition and Stipend), UC Berkeley	2026–2027
Center for African Studies Rocca Pre-dissertation Research Award, UC Berkeley	Summer 2026
Berkeley Economy and Society Initiative Award	Summer 2026
Chancellor's Fellowship (Full Tuition and Stipend), UC Berkeley	2024–2025
Central European University Research Travel Grant	2017
Central European University Master's Excellence Scholarship (Full Tuition and Stipend)	2016
Benjamin A. Gilman International Scholarship	2016
Benjamin Franklin Travel Grant	2015
Dean's List, College of Staten Island	

CONFERENCE PRESENTATIONS

Association of American Geographers Annual Meeting	2026
<i>"What Do You Mean You Have No Forex?": Foreign Exchange Shortages, Food Security, and Economic Development in Landlocked Malawi — Accepted and Presented</i>	
Oxford Food Symposium	2026
<i>"From Poverty Food to Global Superfood: Can Fonio Escape the Quinoa Trap?" — Accepted and Presented</i>	
Society for the Advancement of Socio-Economics	2026
<i>"Quinoa and Teff Ran so Fonio Could Walk: Beyond the Superfood Cycle and Toward a Proactive Political Economy of Fonio and Underutilized Species" — Accepted</i>	

SKILLS

Languages: English (Native), Dagbanli (Native), Twi (Proficient), Hausa (Proficient), French (Elementary)

Research Methods: Household Surveys, Focus Groups, Key Informant Interviews, Participant Observation

Technology: Microsoft Office, G Suite, ArcGIS, SPSS

Project Management: Asana, Miro, Airtable